Identifying strengths and weaknesses

Take a few minutes to jot down what's working well in your current study routine. What areas could use some improvement? Consider factors like time management, focus, and understanding of different subjects.

Setting realistic goals

Based on your assessment, you could start by setting 2-3 specific, achievable goals for improving your study habits. Make these goals SMART: Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound. Write them down and place them somewhere visible as a daily reminder.

Now that you know where you stand, it's time to map out a path to exam success. Think of your study schedule as a roadmap to help you navigate your way through VCE studies.

Time management tips

List all your subjects and the topics you need to cover for each. Assess how much time you have until your exams. Consider prioritising subjects based on difficulty and your current performance. Using a study schedule template Remember: Be realistic with your schedule. If you're not a morning person, a sunrise study session may not suit you. Try to work with your natural rhythms, and not against them.

Find a study schedule template that works for you – digital or physical, whichever works best.

Block out fixed commitments like school, extracurriculars, and family time. Allocate study blocks for each subject, ensuring a mix of subjects each day. Don't forget to schedule breaks and 'me time' to avoid feelings of burnout.

A cluttered space can contribute to a cluttered mind. Here are some strategies to effectively organise your study materials.

Gathering resources

Collect all your textbooks, notes, and past papers for each subject. Organise digital resources into clearly labelled folders on your computer. Consider creating a 'study toolkit' with essentials like highlighters, sticky notes, and index cards.

Creating a study-friendly environment

Find a quiet, well-lit space where you can focus without distractions. Ensure you have a comfortable chair and desk at the right height. Keep your study area clean and organised – a tidy space can do wonders for your concentration.

Below are some tried and true study techniques you might like to explore.

The power of self-testing

After studying a topic, close your books and try to recall as much as you can. Create flashcards for key concepts and test yourself regularly. Explain concepts out loud as if you're teaching someone else.

Spacing out your study sessions

Avoid cramming by spreading out your study sessions over time. Review material at increasing intervals: e.g. 1 day later, 3 days later, 1 week later, etc.

Another way to effectively prepare for exams is by practising past exams. Here are some techniques you might find helpful.

Simulating exam conditions

Find past papers or practice exams for your subjects. Set up a quiet space and time yourself as you would in a real exam. Avoid using your notes or textbooks during these practice sessions.

Analysing your performance

Mark your practice exams using the relevant marking schemes, if available. Identify areas where you lost marks and focus on improving these in your study sessions. Keep a log of common mistakes to avoid repeating them in the real exam.

It's important to look after yourself and practice self-care during this time. Find what works best for you, or try our ideas below.

Incorporating breaks and relaxation

Use techniques like the Pomodoro method: 25 minutes of focused study followed by a 5-minute break. Schedule longer breaks for activities you enjoy – maybe a quick game of

basketball or a chat with friends. Practice mindfulness or meditation to help manage stress and improve focus.

Maintaining physical and mental well-being

Aim for 7-9 hours of sleep per night – your brain consolidates memories and learning during sleep. Incorporate regular exercise to improve your mood and reduce stress. Eat a balanced diet with brain-boosting foods like blueberries, nuts, and fatty fish.

Two heads are better than one, and a study group can be a powerhouse of knowledge, inspiration and motivation.

The benefits of peer learning

Explaining concepts to others can help solidify your own understanding. Gain new perspectives and insights from your peers. Stay motivated and accountable with group study sessions.

Organising effective study sessions

Set clear objectives for each study session. Use tools like shared Google Docs or virtual whiteboards for collaborative note-taking.

Remember, asking for help isn't a sign of weakness.

Utilising teacher support

Don't hesitate to approach your teachers with specific questions. Attend any extra help sessions offered by your school or community. Ask for feedback on your work.

Exploring additional resources

Explore online tutorials or video explanations for challenging topics. Consider getting a tutor for subjects where you're really struggling. Join online forums or study groups for your specific subjects.

When your exams are approaching – make sure you're feeling prepared.

Pre-exam preparation

Get a good night's sleep before the exam. Eat a nutritious breakfast to fuel your brain. Arrive at the exam venue early to avoid last-minute stress.

During the exam tactics

Read through the entire paper before starting to answer questions. Manage your time wisely – allocate minutes to each section based on mark values. If you get stuck on a question, move on and come back to it later.

Weeks 12–11 · Rebuild the foundations

- **Read:** your text's Background and Context and Values chapters (Picnic at Hanging Rock / The Lottery and Other Stories), then What is Needed in an Essay.
- **Do:** re-watch the film / re-read the play once, casually. Skim the scene summaries or quote tables alongside.
- **Tool:** 10 minutes of Quote Flashcards daily — start building recall now, when it's cheap.

Weeks 10–9 · Master the evidence

- **Read:** the Thematic and Character Quote Banks for your text, and the Symbols chapters.
- **Do:** build a one-page theme map: each major theme, three quotes, one symbol, one technique. The Glossary supplies the technique names.
- **Tool:** flashcards daily; add the Technique Quiz twice a week.

Weeks 8–7 · Learn the craft of the essay

- **Read:** Interrogating the Topic, then plan paragraphs with the Th.E.S.A.M.L. scaffold in the Essay Outline Builder.
- **Study:** one annotated exemplar per week (SB / RE) — click through every highlight, one colour category at a time.
- **Tool:** Essay Outline Builder — plan two essays per week without writing them. Micro-Drills for topic sentences.

Weeks 6–5 · Write, mark, rewrite

- **Do:** one full timed Section A essay per week (Practice Topics & Timer, 60 minutes). Swap with a friend and mark each other against the criteria.
- **Read:** the 2024 and 2025 assessor takeaways — especially the topic-verb guidance.
- **Fix:** run a paragraph through the Vocabulary Upgrader after each essay.

Weeks 4–3 · Sections B and C

- **Read:** Creating Texts with its three scored sample pieces, and Analysing Argument including the vocabulary bank.
- **Do:** one timed Section B piece and one timed Section C analysis per week, and mark both against the criteria. Use the practice stimuli and practice articles.

Weeks 2 · Full dress rehearsals

- **Do:** at least one complete three-hour exam under conditions — the Exam Generator makes a fresh paper, or use a practice exam. Fifteen minutes reading time, no phone, all three sections.
- **Mark:** every section against the criteria; note which section costs you most and give it the spare hours this week.

Week 1 · Final week

- **Read:** the Exam Checklists, the Priority Checklist for 2027, and Exam Format one last time.
- **Do:** light passes of the quote banks and flashcards; one plan a day with the Outline Builder — no more full essays after mid-week. Sleep is revision.

Pair this program with the advice in the rest of Effectively Studying For Exams — spaced repetition, study-life balance, and exam-day strategy.